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Bumrah's off-cutter is also known to induce a very similar effect — an outcome of his unique bowling action and wrist usage. Its devastating impact was on full display in the final, when the Indian pacer scalped four wickets with his swerving cutters to set up a massive win for his team.

Bumrah leaned on his experience to devise a bowling plan to exploit the Ahmedabad surface that usually rewards pace-off deliveries. Of the 24 deliveries he bowled in the final, 18 were off-cutters. "Because of the experience, because I've played on beltors over here, and I have seen the other teams too, I learned that trying to bowl too fast can make shot-making easier. So, I just played smart and tried to think of what the batsmen were trying to do," said Bumrah after he received the Player-of-the-Final award.

What makes Bumrah's cutters more potent is the angle from which

he delivers them. This World Cup, 76.7 per cent of his off-cutters were delivered from wide of the crease (over the wicket). Only West Indies' Jason Holder had a bigger such share.

This, along with his anatomically freakish bowling technique, creates an awkward line of attack for Bumrah, granting him an advantage even before his off-cutter bounces. Half of his 14 wickets in the tournament came with this variation.

Much before Ngidi and Bumrah rocked batting units with their mastery over the off-cutter, another bowler had wreaked havoc with this delivery in the tournament — USA's Shadley van Schalkwyk (**above**).

The unheralded American, with his dabbly-dobbly medium pace, harvested 13 wickets from four group-stage games, including identical four-wicket hauls (4/25) against India and Pakistan.

Van Schalkwyk's natural pace, or

rather the lack of it, meant his cutters held onto the surface a fraction longer, resulting in batters frequently mistiming against him.

The 38-year-old bowled 18 off-cutters in the 2026 edition and gained an incredible six wickets from them. The idea, as Van Schalkwyk explained, was to take the batters out of their comfort zone.

"I know my variations. It was about making the ball as slow as possible for them [Indian batters], because it looks like they quite enjoy it when it comes on. So, technically, I wanted to take it away from their hitting zones," he said in an interview with *ESPNCricinfo* after the India game. In recent years, armed with superior bats and favourable conditions, batters have gained significant ground in T20 cricket. This World Cup saw pacers hold their ground by returning to an age-old weapon — the seemingly unassuming off-cutter.